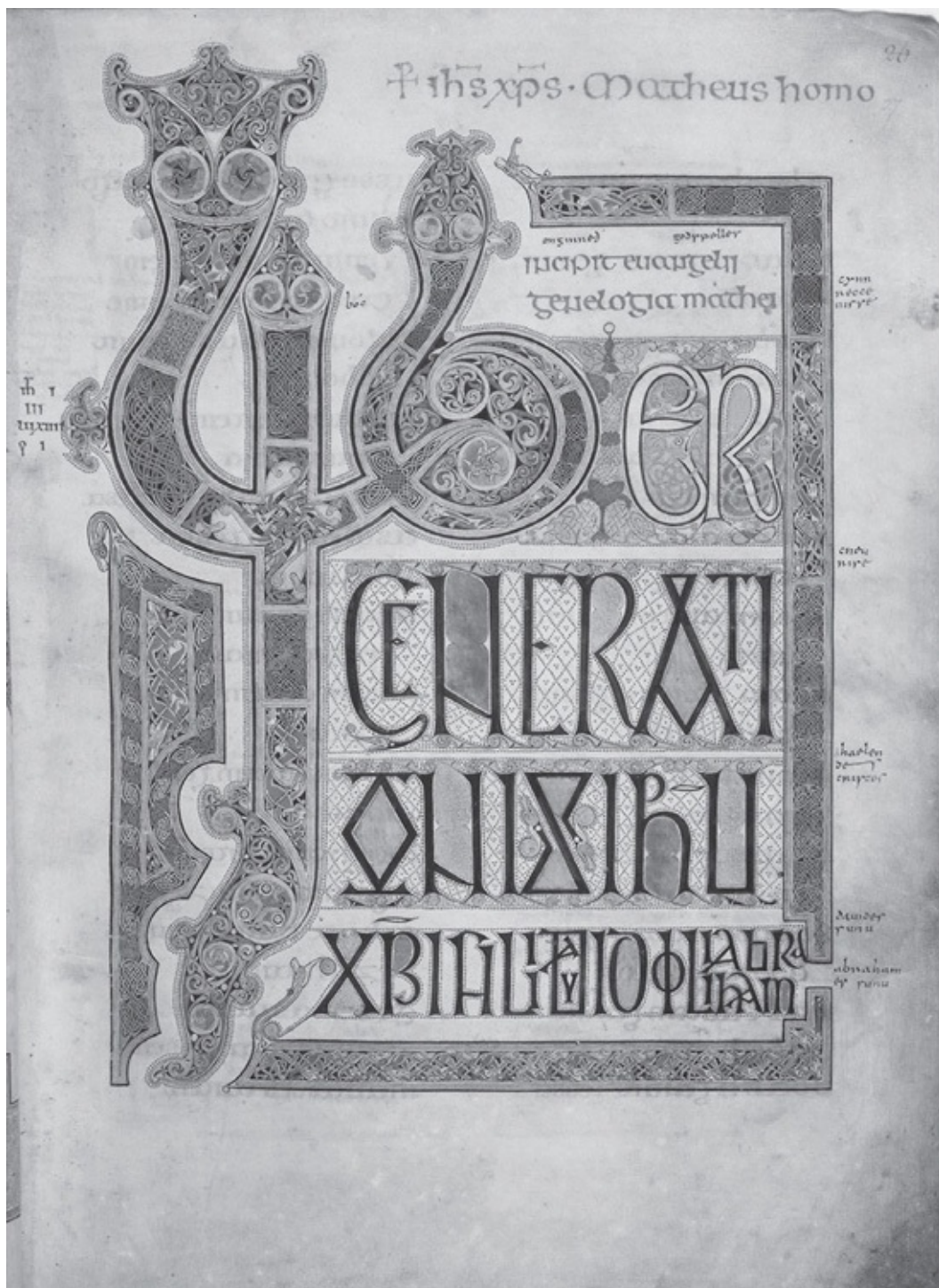


Celtic and Viking art

The most powerful art in the British Isles from 500–1000 CE was Celtic. The Celts were tribes who originated in central Europe in the sixth century BCE and gradually migrated to Britain. As the Romans never conquered Ireland or Scotland, Celtic art flourished there. Based on semi-abstract designs, it manifested in metalwork, stonework and illuminated manuscripts, such as the Lindisfarne Gospels (c.650–750) and the Book of Kells (c.800). Rich and elaborate decorations follow colourful, intricate patterns, including tracery, spirals, steps and knotwork.

Viking or Norse art, produced in the British Isles and Iceland during the 8th to 11th centuries CE, manifested in swirling and interlaced patterns and abstracted animals on brooches, weapons, tools and ships. Influences can be seen from Celtic, Romanesque and Eastern European art. Viking craftsmen excelled in woodwork and metalwork, and as they often moved around, much of the art is portable and is generally more functional and symbolic than expressive.



Page from the Lindisfarne Gospels, c.700 CE